out of the Utkal Alumina Project, a ‘Rs 4,000-crore joint venture between Norsk Hydro, Alcan, Indal Company Limited and TISCO’.

**Customer Focus**

Customer focus was the third component of Ratan’s strategy. In his first AGM as chairman, TISCO, Ratan emphasized the necessity of making the customer the focus. He underscored the ‘need to establish closer links with regional manufacturers and with its major customers so as to better understand customer applications as well as provide improved customer support both in terms of delivery and support’. The following year, he elaborated that steel was a commodity and the company should distinguish itself from others by ensuring customer satisfaction through higher quality of its products and services. This approach would ‘enable Tata Steel to remain competitive in the coming years’.

The result was that towards the end of 1994, TISCO became ‘more of a market oriented company’ than a ‘production driven company’. In an interview, Ratan reiterated that his emphasis was on ‘satisfying the customer’. He added that he was working towards ensuring that the company benchmarked itself to the best in the world, rather than to its own past. Commenting on the transformation, Irani would say, ‘In the past, TISCO was like a Wild West store where there was something for everyone. Now we’re concentrating on three to four products.’

Ratan also tapped into the digital world and used e-commerce to reach out to customers. In this effort, he benefited from the advice of ‘MIT’s director of Computer Laboratory Science, Michael Dertouzos’. TISCO concluded a JV agreement with SAIL and Kalyani Steel to launch Metaljunction.com and undertake ‘e-commerce activities in the steel sector’.

For Ratan, the emphasis on customer orientation was a recurring theme. In 2002, he reiterated this priority, stating that the company would now be ‘paying particular attention to technically supporting customers in finding solutions to meet their needs in its increasing endeavour to differentiate itself from the rest of the Indian steel industry, while at the same time retaining its position as one of the lowest cost steel producers in the world’.

In the AGM of 2003, Ratan reemphasized the importance of improving customer focus. He said that because of the ‘inevitable volatility of